DO FAULT ZONES ROUTE ROAD-SALT-CONTAMINATED GROUNDWATER TO STREAMS? A HUDSON VALLEY, NY CASE STUDY

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ABSTRACT

Road salt applied to highways has salinized streams across the northeastern United States, and much of that salt is stored in groundwater and released to streams for years to decades, keeping stream salinity high even during summer baseflow. Where this stored salt re-enters streams is poorly understood. High-angle geologic faults are one candidate pathway: their fractured damage zones can channel groundwater, and road salt has been traced into fractured-bedrock wells, where it persists year-round. However, it has not been tested whether faults deliver this water to streams at locations a stream survey can detect. We asked whether mapped faults in the Hudson Valley, New York, coincide with abrupt increases in stream specific conductance, a proxy for salinity. We surveyed specific conductance along three reaches of Wappinger Creek crossed by mapped faults, compared reaches upstream and downstream of fault crossings and tributary junctions, applied change-point analysis to locate where conductance changed, and measured one chloride transect. Comparisons were valid only within a single survey day: pooling two survey days created an apparent 18 μS/cm step at one fault that fell to a non-significant 1.6 μS/cm within a day. Of three fault crossings, only one showed a small significant increase (4.3 μS/cm), and it was a gradual rise beginning about 1.6 km upstream rather than a step at the fault. No conductance breakpoint coincided with a fault, while the tributary junction at Site 3 lowered conductance as mixing predicts. Road proximity, wastewater discharges and salt stored in soils remain plausible alternative sources. This low-cost survey therefore does not clearly show fault-routed transport. We outline a falsifiable test combining single-day surveys, discharge measurements, chloride-to-bromide ratios, age tracers and field-located faults.

Keywords water quality · fault lines · salinity · de-icing · roadway management

1 Introduction

Road salt has been used as a de-icing agent in the United States since the 1940s, and its use has climbed steadily decade over decade [1, 2]. It is indispensable for winter road safety, but it also poses a widespread salinization threat to fresh waters across cold-climate regions [3, 4]. Application rates vary widely between jurisdictions [5]. Beyond corroding vehicles and infrastructure [6], road salt contaminates groundwater and degrades stream water quality [2, 7], with ecological effects that include longer-term shifts in ecosystem function [8]. These effects occur at chloride concentrations at or below existing regulatory guidelines: Hintz et al. [9] found that chloride at or beneath current water-quality thresholds caused substantial losses of zooplankton in lakes across North America and Europe. Identifying *where* salt enters streams, and therefore where mitigation would be most effective, thus carries direct management value.

Although road salt is applied only in the cold months, its effects on freshwater salinity extend across the entire year [10]. Chloride concentrations are highest in winter [11], but stored salt keeps stream salinity elevated into the summer [12], when groundwater inputs sustain many perennial streams at baseflow. Road salt reaches groundwater, in some settings partly through leakage from salt-laden streams [13]. Through exchange between groundwater and streams,

summertime stream salt concentrations have continued to rise, with long-term increases documented in the northeastern United States and Canada [3, 7]. Much of the applied chloride accumulates in groundwater and is released to streams over years to decades [14], so summer baseflow salinity integrates decades of past application rather than the most recent winter alone. This raises the question of what controls where that stored salt re-emerges.

Fault zones are one candidate control. They are commonly described as conduit–barrier systems, in which a low-permeability core is flanked by a fractured damage zone that can favor flow along the fault while hindering flow across it; whether a particular fault acts as a conduit, a barrier, or both depends on its architecture and hydrogeologic setting [15, 16]. In New England, road salt reaches groundwater in fractured bedrock: in Maine, Schalk and Stasulis [17] traced salt in four bedrock wells beside state roads, with specific conductance elevated in summer as well as winter, and they note that the state's highest-yielding bedrock wells coincide with faults and other geologic structures. Studies in the region's metamorphic bedrock also point to structural control of groundwater flow: foliation-parallel fractures can raise connectivity and add flow anisotropy [18], and the Hinesburg thrust fault in Vermont influences well yield and water chemistry [19]. These studies leave open whether faults carry road salt and deliver it to streams: the Maine evidence links salt to bedrock fractures rather than to a particular fault, and we found little direct evidence that faults route highway road salt to surface water. Resolving this matters because it would identify streams at risk through a fault even where no road runs nearby.

Salinization is increasingly viewed as a coupled process, the "freshwater salinization syndrome" [20] or "anthropogenic salt cycle" [21], in which geology and hydrologic flowpaths are among five proposed state factors driving salinization [22]. This motivates a search for the specific structures that concentrate delivery of stored salt to surface water.

Tributary confluences are a more familiar cause of abrupt longitudinal changes in stream conductance. Where a tributary joins the main stem, the conductance downstream of the junction is approximately the discharge-weighted average of the two inflowing waters, a two-end-member mixing relation of the kind used to separate flow components from tracer concentrations [23]. A tributary with lower conductance than the main stem therefore dilutes it, and one with higher conductance raises it, by an amount set by the ratio of discharges and the contrast in conductance. A step in conductance at a confluence is thus expected without any fault. A step at a fault crossing with no tributary entering requires a different explanation, such as solute added from groundwater along the reach. Dilution by a tributary could also partly mask a groundwater input at the same location, which we cannot separate without discharge measurements. We therefore treat tributary and fault boundaries as distinct kinds of contrast.

We ask whether sharp increases in stream salinity coincide spatially with mapped high-angle faults in a way consistent with fault-conduit transport of road-salt-contaminated groundwater from highway to stream. If faults do route such groundwater to streams, three predictions follow. First, where a conductive fault crosses a channel, salt-laden groundwater discharging along the structure should produce an abrupt, localized rise in specific conductance between the reaches immediately upstream and downstream of the crossing, rather than the gradual downstream drift expected from diffuse inputs; dense longitudinal surveys have been used to locate point groundwater inputs of road salt to streams in this way [24–26]. Second, the step should persist during baseflow in summer and early autumn, when groundwater-fed baseflow supplies much of the streamflow at low flow [27]. Third, it should be reflected in chloride, and in chloride-to-bromide ratios, which are widely used to distinguish deicing salt from other chloride sources [28].

We test these predictions with a case study of Wappinger Creek in Dutchess County, New York, combining dense longitudinal surveys of specific conductance, mapped fault traces, and a single chloride transect. We focused on reaches where mapped high-angle faults cross the channel. The study is a hypothesis-generating screening case study: it can show whether the predicted pattern is visible in a low-cost survey, and what a conclusive test would require, but it cannot by itself demonstrate that faults transport road salt.

2 Methods

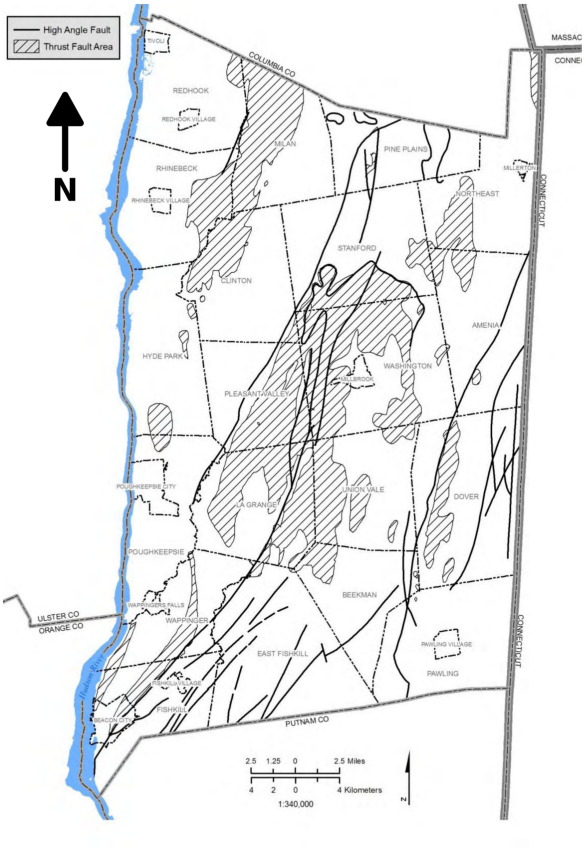
2.1 Site description

For our study we selected three segments of Wappinger Creek, a tributary to the Hudson River in Dutchess County, New York, USA. Each site was chosen based on two factors: whether one or more high-angle faults intersect the stream, and whether the segment could be accessed safely for field measurements. A geologic fault-line map of Dutchess County [29] allowed us to locate each stream intersection with a high-angle fault and to create a map (Figure 1) containing both fault lines and major roads. Wappinger Creek intersects State Highways 44, 55, and 9, as well as the Taconic State Parkway, in various sections. Multiple faults bisect the creek in its upper East Branch and its middle section, and the traces of some of these structures appear to control the channel's course, most visibly at Sites 1 and 2.

Budnik et al. [29] describe the fault locations as "largely conjectural since the faults themselves are rarely exposed at the surface" (p. 18), so the mapped traces are approximate and we draw them as lines without an error zone.

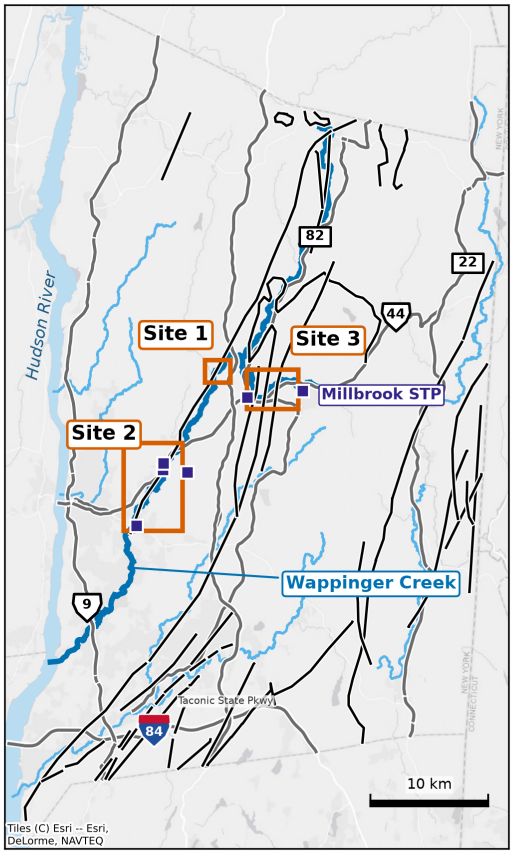
The bedrock beneath the study area consists of metamorphosed clastic sedimentary rocks that were folded and faulted during the Taconic Orogeny, and it is cut by low-angle thrust faults as well as steeper, high-angle faults [29]. This structural setting is central to our hypothesis, because fault zones typically comprise a fractured, high-permeability damage zone flanking a lower-permeability core, and can therefore behave as preferential conduits, as barriers, or as combined conduit–barrier systems for groundwater flow [15, 16]. If the high-angle faults crossing Wappinger Creek are conduits, they could in principle route road-salt-laden groundwater from a highway to the channel even where the two are separated by a topographic divide, which motivated our focus on stream reaches that coincide with mapped fault traces. Whether they do so is the question we test.

(a) Budnik et al. (2010) fault map



Taken directly from Budnik, Walker & Menking (2010), Fig. 3.10, Natural Resource Inventory of Dutchess County, NY.

(b) Study area: faults, highways and streams



High-angle fault (Budnik et al. 2010) | Major highway | Interstate
Wappinger Creek | Study site | US route
Other major streams | Wastewater facility | NY State route

Figure 1: Study area. (a) High-angle faults and thrust-fault areas in Dutchess County, reproduced from Budnik et al. [29], Fig. 3.10. (b) The three study reaches (orange boxes) on Wappinger Creek, with faults digitized from panel (a), wastewater facilities (squares) and major highways. Sources: USGS NHD, US Census TIGER, EPA ECHO, Esri.

2.2 In-situ sampling

Conductivity measurements were made on four days in autumn 2018: Site 1 on 28 September, Site 2 on 5 October, and Site 3 on 19 and 26 October. The two Site 3 days correspond to three field surveys: one on 19 October (field site 3), and two on 26 October: an upper survey (field site 5) that repeats Zones 3-1 and 3-2, and a lower survey (field site 4) that continues downstream from the end of the 19 October survey. We measured from upstream to downstream, approximately every 100 m at Sites 1 and 3 and about every 400 m along the longer Site 2 reach, traversing either on foot inside or around the creek or floating along the channel. Sampling was performed in the thalweg of each study site, which reduced variation due to incomplete lateral mixing. We used a Thermo Scientific Orion 013010MD conductivity

cell, calibrated following the standard protocols outlined by the manufacturer, with readings temperature-compensated to 25 °C and reported as specific conductance. We inferred changes in the salt input to the stream along its length from changes in specific conductance. The meters used with this cell specify an accuracy of $\pm 0.5\%$ of reading ± 1 digit, about ± 1.7 μS/cm at 310 μS/cm. A calibration offset shared by all readings on one day cancels when zones are compared within that day; random reading error does not.

Mean spacing between points was about 85 m at Site 1, 416 m at Site 2 and 83–118 m on the Site 3 surveys, yielding 9, 18, and 46 measurement points at Sites 1, 2, and 3, respectively, with point positions recorded using a handheld GPS unit. Along-channel distance for each survey was computed by summing great-circle distances between consecutive GPS fixes in survey order, with the surveys that were walked upstream reversed so that distance increases downstream. Within each site we delineated zones bounded at fault positions interpreted in the field or where the creek receives an active tributary, so that the reaches immediately upstream and downstream of a single geologic or hydrologic feature could be compared directly. To isolate the effect of faults, we restricted our fault-crossing contrasts to reaches where the creek intersects a mapped fault without a coincident tributary, because a tributary confluence introduces an independent salinity signal that would confound the comparison. Because the fault traces are mapped at county scale, we treated each crossing as a reach-scale rather than a point-scale feature. We placed each fault boundary at an abrupt, roughly right-angle turn of the channel, which we took to be the creek turning to follow a fault; these field positions lie within a few hundred meters of, but not exactly at, the digitized trace crossings. Survey points located downstream of a fault are called fault points (Figures 2–6 and Appendix A). Zones are numbered such that they ascend as the river goes downstream: for example zone 3-3 is downstream of 3-2 which is downstream of 3-1. This gives five upstream/downstream contrasts (Table 1): A (Zones 1-1/1-2, tributary), B (2-1/2-2, fault), C (3-1/3-2, tributary), D (3-2/3-3, first fault) and E (3-3/3-4, second fault). At Site 2 the digitized county-scale trace runs along the creek for the whole surveyed reach, so it cannot resolve where the fault crosses the channel. The boundary between Zones 2-1 and 2-2 (Contrast B), about 4 km along the survey, is therefore placed at such a bend, a roughly 90° turn of the channel. An abrupt bend is consistent with structural control of the channel, but it does not by itself show that groundwater flows along the fault there.

On 20 July 2020 we measured chloride along a 2.35 km transect of the East Branch at Site 3, from point Z (0 m) to point Z′ (2,351 m), passing the long-term monitoring site of Kelly et al. [30] at about 1,224 m (Figure 5). The aim was to see whether chloride rose near the mapped faults. We took 18 samples in the main channel and one in a side tributary. Chloride was measured with a calibrated YSI Pro Series 1005 chloride ion-selective electrode (YSI 605105) on a YSI handheld meter. The manufacturer gives an accuracy of $\pm 15\%$ of reading or ± 5 mg/L, whichever is greater, which at our concentrations (about 14–50 mg/L) is ± 5 to ± 7.5 mg/L, so differences of a few mg/L between neighboring samples are within instrument error.

The transect was sampled in midsummer, when streamflow is likely dominated by baseflow, so elevated chloride is more plausibly from groundwater than from runoff. Because it is a single transect from a different year than the conductivity survey, it cannot confirm the conductivity pattern, and we treat it as descriptive.

2.3 Statistical analysis

For each contrast we applied a two-sample Welch t-test (Equation 1) to evaluate the difference in mean specific conductance, in μS/cm, upstream and downstream of each feature. Unlike Student's pooled t-test, Welch's version does not assume equal variances and remains reliable with unequal sample sizes, as ours are, and is recommended as the default two-sample test [31].

$$t = \frac{\overline{x}_2 - \overline{x}_1}{\sqrt{\dfrac{s_1^2}{n_1} + \dfrac{s_2^2}{n_2}}} \tag{1}$$

Here $\overline{x}_1$ and $\overline{x}_2$ are the mean specific conductance of the upstream and downstream zones, s_1 and s_2 their standard deviations, and n_1 and n_2 their sample sizes. Zones are compared only within a single survey day. Synoptic comparisons along a stream assume steady conditions, because concentrations that change between sampling runs are a source of uncertainty in a longitudinal profile [32]. At Site 3 the two survey days differ by a large offset (about 28 μS/cm; Section 3.1), larger than any of the contrasts we test. We did not pool days, add a day covariate, or correct for the offset. Contrast D is therefore tested on 19 October, and Contrast E on 26 October. We evaluated significance with two-tailed tests at $\alpha = 0.05$. Because our zone samples are relatively small and not guaranteed to be normally distributed, we accompanied every Welch test with a distribution-free Mann–Whitney U test and regard a contrast as robust only where the two approaches agree, which guards against over-interpreting the smaller contrasts.

Applying a t-test to measurements collected sequentially along a channel warrants caution, because closely spaced samples are not strictly independent and nominal p-values are therefore likely too small. For each contrast we estimated the lag-1 autocorrelation ρ of the residuals from the two zone means, pooled in along-channel order. Negative values were set to zero and ρ was capped at 0.9. We then computed an effective sample size for each zone, $n_{\text{eff}} = n(1-\rho)/(1+\rho)$, floored at 2 and not exceeding n, and repeated the Welch test with n_{eff} in place of n (degrees of freedom by the Welch–Satterthwaite approximation). With zones of three to eleven points, ρ is poorly determined, so we treat the adjusted p-values as a sensitivity check rather than a correction.

Zone means cannot show whether a change in conductance is abrupt or gradual, so we also looked for change points along each transect. For each single-day transect separately (Site 1, Site 2, the 19 October survey at Site 3, and the upper and lower 26 October surveys at Site 3), we fitted continuous piecewise-linear regressions of specific conductance on along-channel distance with zero, one, or two breakpoints, requiring at least three points in each segment, and chose the number of breakpoints by the Bayesian information criterion (BIC). Uncertainty in each breakpoint was assessed with a residual bootstrap (500 replicates). As an independent check we applied a penalized change-in-mean analysis (PELT, `ruptures` package). The same procedure was applied to the chloride transect.

Finally, because roads are a possible alternative source of the conductance differences, we computed the distance from each survey point to the nearest major road, defined as primary or secondary roads (TIGER/Line 2024 feature classes S1100 and S1200; the Taconic State Parkway is coded as a local road, S1400, and is therefore excluded). We report these distances descriptively by zone and do not test them.

3 Results

3.1 Within-day zone contrasts

Zones are compared only within a single survey day, so the results are reported survey by survey. Table 1 gives each contrast with zone means ± SD and the number of points n; Table 2 gives the autocorrelation-adjusted p-values and the median distance from each zone's points to the nearest major road; Appendix A lists every measurement. Within a single day the zone standard deviations are 0.1–2.6 μS/cm.

Site 1, Contrast A (28 September). Specific conductance fell from 259.9 ± 0.7 μS/cm in Zone 1-1 ($n = 4$) to 259.4 ± 0.1 μS/cm in Zone 1-2 ($n = 5$), a change of -0.5 μS/cm that is not significant (Figure 2; Table 1). A tributary enters at the same place where the channel turns along the mapped fault trace, and we surveyed Site 1 at very high flow after rain; conductance there was 50–100 μS/cm lower than at the other sites, consistent with dilution by runoff, so this contrast cannot isolate a fault effect and, with four and five points, has little power.

Site 2, Contrast B (5 October). Zone 2-1 averaged 308.8 ± 1.1 μS/cm ($n = 10$) and Zone 2-2 averaged 313.1 ± 1.9 μS/cm ($n = 8$), an increase of $+4.3$ μS/cm (95% CI $+2.6$ to $+6.0$; Welch $p < 0.001$; Mann–Whitney $p < 0.001$; Figure 3). Allowing for autocorrelation along the channel ($n_{\text{eff}} = 4.6$ and 3.7), the adjusted p is 0.017 (Table 2). The difference is larger than the within-zone standard deviations and about 2.5 times the instrument's stated accuracy at this conductance (±1.7 μS/cm at 310 μS/cm). The Zone 2-1/2-2 boundary, about 4.0 km along the survey, is the fault position we interpreted in the field from the abrupt 90° channel bend (Section 2.2). The digitized county-scale trace runs along the creek throughout and crosses the survey line at about 1.0 and 5.8 km, but those intersections are not reliable fault positions, so we did not use them. Flow was very high for the duration of the Site 2 survey, and we canoed part of it, so this survey may not represent baseflow.

Site 3, Contrasts C, D and E (19 and 26 October). Figure 4 shows both days. Contrast C, the tributary junction, is a decrease on both days: -3.8 μS/cm on 19 October (340.1 ± 0.4, $n = 6$, to 336.3 ± 2.2, $n = 3$; Welch $p = 0.093$; Mann–Whitney $p = 0.028$) and -5.6 μS/cm on 26 October (370.5 ± 2.6, $n = 11$, to 364.9 ± 1.1, $n = 3$; $p < 0.001$, adjusted $p = 0.041$). On 19 October the two tests disagree, so by the criterion in Section 2.3 this contrast does not meet our robustness criterion; the Mann–Whitney p is an asymptotic value computed with ties and groups of only 6 and 3 points, for which the smallest attainable exact p is about 0.024. The downstream zone has only three points, so these tests have little power. Contrast D, the first fault, can be tested only on 19 October, because on 26 October Zones 3-2 and 3-3 lie on different transects 1.1 km apart. It is a decrease of -2.8 μS/cm (336.3 ± 2.2, $n = 3$, to 333.4 ± 1.9, $n = 11$; 95% CI -7.4 to $+1.7$; $p = 0.140$). Contrast E, the second fault, can be tested only on 26 October. Conductance rose from 358.8 ± 1.8 μS/cm ($n = 6$) in Zone 3-3 to 360.4 ± 0.8 μS/cm ($n = 6$) in Zone 3-4, an increase of $+1.6$ μS/cm (95% CI -0.3 to $+3.4$; Welch $p = 0.090$; Mann–Whitney $p = 0.076$; adjusted $p = 0.243$), which is not significant and within the instrument's stated accuracy (±1.9 μS/cm at 360 μS/cm). The tributary contrast (C) thus behaves as mixing predicts, a decrease where the tributary, which measured nearly 150 μS/cm lower than Zones 3-1 and 3-2, enters, while neither Site 3 fault contrast shows a significant increase.

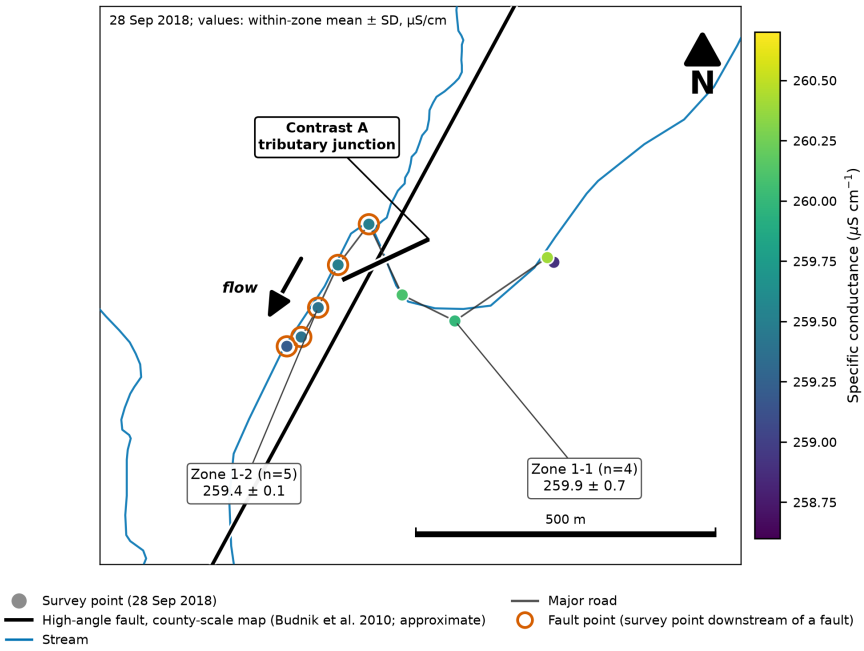


Figure 2: Site 1 (28 September 2018) and Contrast A. Points are colored by specific conductance; orange rings mark fault points. Zone labels give n and mean $\pm$ SD (μS/cm). Faults from Budnik et al. [29].

Pooling days. When the two survey days are pooled, Contrast E appears as a rise of $+18.0$ μS/cm ($p < 0.001$), larger than any other step in the survey. That value is an artifact of pooling two survey days. Zone 3-3 would then combine 11 points from 19 October (333.4 μS/cm) with 6 from 26 October (358.8 μS/cm), giving a pooled mean of 342.4 μS/cm, whereas Zone 3-4 consists only of 26 October points. The "step" is the difference between days, not a change along the channel; the same pooling inflates the zone standard deviations to 12.6–15.8 μS/cm, against 0.4–2.6 μS/cm within a day at Site 3.

Day offset and the repeated reach. Eleven 19 October points have a 26 October point within 120 m, and the pairs differ by 23.5–29.7 μS/cm (mean 27.8, SD 2.2); two points 18 m apart at the seam between the surveys read 332.0 and 355.5 μS/cm. The offset is therefore not constant, and its range of about 6 μS/cm exceeds Contrasts B and E, which is why we neither pooled days nor corrected for it. Zones 3-1 and 3-2 were surveyed on both days (Figure 4, inset): Zone 3-1 averaged 340.1 $\pm$ 0.4 μS/cm ($n = 6$) on 19 October and 370.5 $\pm$ 2.6 ($n = 11$) on 26 October, and Zone 3-2 averaged 336.3 $\pm$ 2.2 ($n = 3$) and 364.9 $\pm$ 1.1 ($n = 3$), so within each day the zones are internally consistent but the two days differ by about 29–30 μS/cm.

3.2 Chloride transect

The 20 July 2020 transect (Figure 5) ran 2,351 m from Z to Z′, starting near the Contrast D fault points and ending just downstream of the Contrast E fault points, so it lies mostly within Zone 3-3. Chloride across the 18 main-stem samples ranged from 13.75 to 50.0 mg/L, with the highest values at 474 m (50.0 mg/L), 690 m (36.25 mg/L) and 959 m (40.0 mg/L). These lie 133–468 m from the nearest Contrast D fault point and 293–391 m from the nearest digitized fault trace. The segmented regression selects one breakpoint at 467 m (bootstrap interval 308–800 m), where the fitted slope changes from $+53$ to -15 mg/L per km; the change-in-mean analysis places shifts at 384 and 1021 m. The breakpoint is about 125 m from the nearest Contrast D fault point and about 300 m from the nearest trace, but it is driven largely by the single 50 mg/L sample. Near Contrast E, chloride is low and flat: only 2 of the 18 samples lie downstream of the Contrast E fault points (13.75 and 15.0 mg/L), and the last five samples are 13.75–17.5 mg/L. The transect therefore shows no chloride increase at Contrast E. With so few points downstream of E we did not attempt a two-sample test.

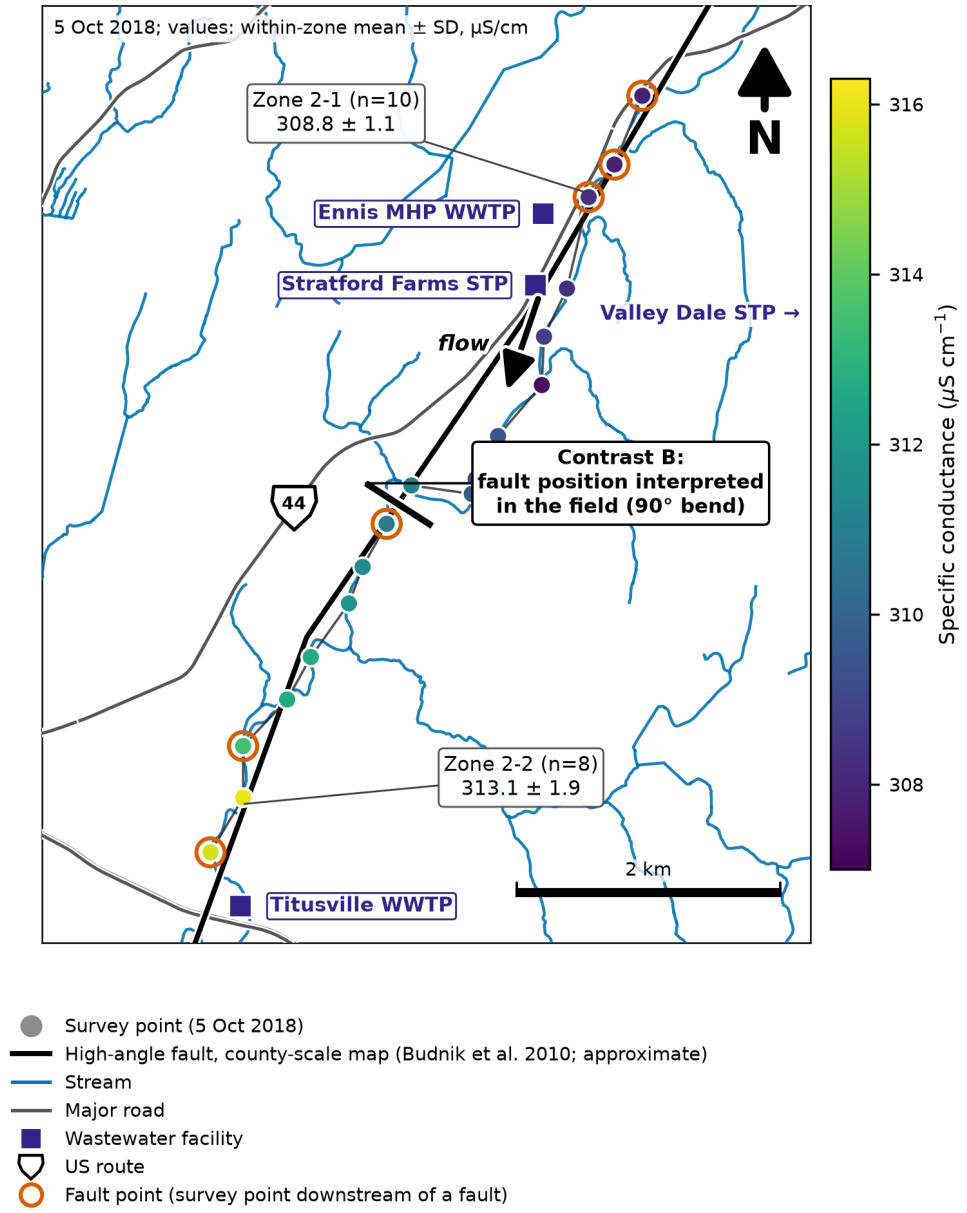


Figure 3: Site 2 (5 October 2018) and Contrast B. Symbols as in Figure 2. The zone boundary is the fault position interpreted in the field at an abrupt 90° bend; squares are wastewater facilities.

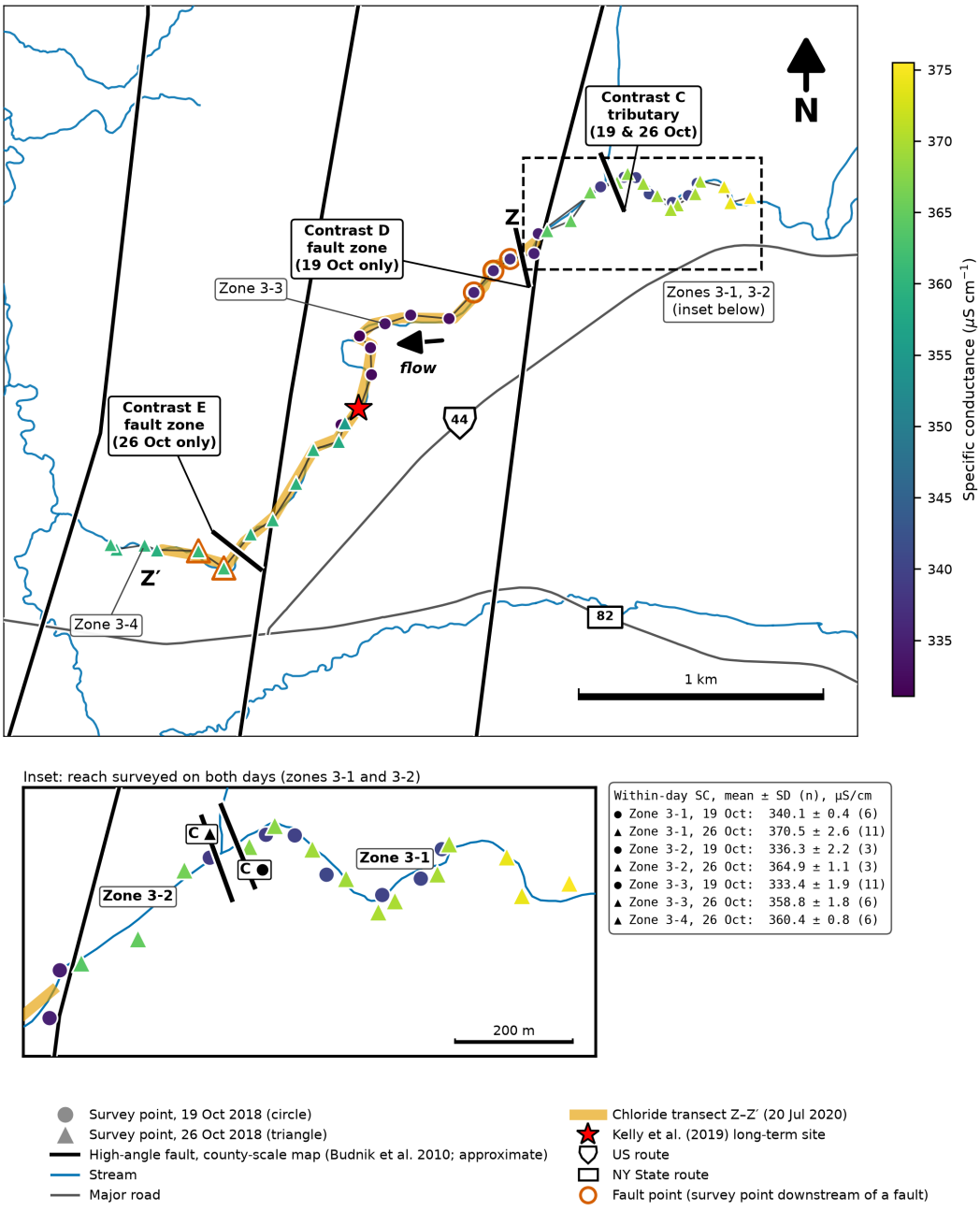


Figure 4: Site 3 and Contrasts C, D and E. Circles are 19 October and triangles 26 October 2018 points; the two days differ by about 28 μS/cm, so zones are compared within a day only. Orange rings mark fault points. The inset enlarges the reach surveyed on both days. The yellow band is the 2020 chloride transect (Z–Z′) and the red star the monitoring site of Kelly et al. [30].

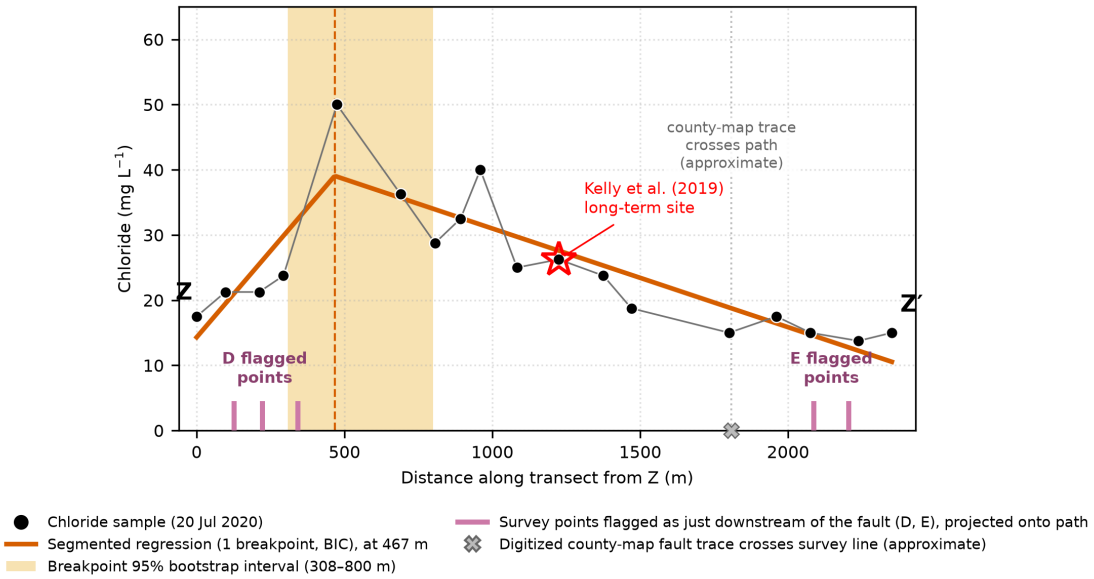


Figure 5: Chloride along the 20 July 2020 transect (Z–Z′). The orange line is the segmented fit, with its breakpoint (467 m) and 95% interval (tan); the breakpoint rests largely on the single 50 mg/L sample. Pink ticks mark the fault points at Contrasts D and E, the gray cross where the digitized fault trace crosses the transect, and the red star the monitoring site of Kelly et al. [30].

3.3 Change-point analysis of specific conductance

Segmented regression and a change-in-mean check on each single-day transect (Figure 6) find no specific-conductance breakpoint at a fault contrast boundary or at a point where the digitized trace crosses the transect. At Site 2 one breakpoint is selected at 2,355 m (bootstrap interval 1,327–3,384 m), after which conductance rises steadily downstream; the fitted slope increases from 0.1 to 1.6 μS/cm per km. This breakpoint lies about 1.6 km upstream of the Contrast B boundary, the field-interpreted fault position at the channel bend (3,993 m; 0.6–2.7 km given the bootstrap interval); the change-in-mean analysis places three small shifts ($+1.5$, $+2.3$ and $+3.3$ μS/cm) between 2.6 and 5.9 km. Contrast B is therefore better described as part of a gradual downstream ramp than as an abrupt step at the interpreted fault position. At Site 1 and on the 19 October Site 3 transect no breakpoint is selected (for 19 October a one-breakpoint model ties with none, ΔBIC = 0.03). On the upper 26 October Site 3 transect two breakpoints (300 and 459 m) are only marginally preferred (ΔBIC = 0.3) and lie 314–473 m from the tributary and away from any trace. On the lower 26 October transect (Contrast E) one breakpoint is selected at 194 m, where conductance rises from 355.5 to 359.7 μS/cm over the first 190 m and then stays near 360 μS/cm. This breakpoint sits at the three-point minimum segment the method allows, 330 m upstream of where the channel crosses the digitized trace (at 523 m), 123 m in straight-line distance from the nearest trace, and 522 m upstream of the Contrast E boundary.

Table 1: Within-day zone contrasts in specific conductance (μS/cm). Δ is downstream minus upstream, with its Welch 95% CI; U and p_{MW} are from the Mann–Whitney test. † marks a zone with fewer than five points.

Contr.	Boundary	Date	Zones	n_1, n_2	Up (mean±SD)	Down (mean±SD)	Δ [95% CI]	Welch t (df)	p	U	p_{MW}
A	tributary	28 Sep	1-1→1-2	4,5†	259.9±0.7	259.4±0.1	-0.5 [-1.5, +0.6]	-1.35 (3.2)	0.264	5	0.266
B	fault	5 Oct	2-1→2-2	10,8	308.8±1.1	313.1±1.9	+4.3 [+2.6, +6.0]	5.63 (10.8)	<0.001	79	<0.001
C	tributary	19 Oct	3-1→3-2	6,3†	340.1±0.4	336.3±2.2	-3.8 [-9.2, +1.5]	-2.97 (2.1)	0.093	0	0.028
C	tributary	26 Oct	3-1→3-2	11,3†	370.5±2.6	364.9±1.1	-5.6 [-7.9, -3.3]	-5.48 (8.8)	<0.001	0	0.012
D	fault	19 Oct	3-2→3-3	3,11†	336.3±2.2	333.4±1.9	-2.8 [-7.4, +1.7]	-2.02 (2.9)	0.140	6	0.119
E	fault	26 Oct	3-3→3-4	6,6	358.8±1.8	360.4±0.8	+1.6 [-0.3, +3.4]	1.96 (7.0)	0.090	30	0.076

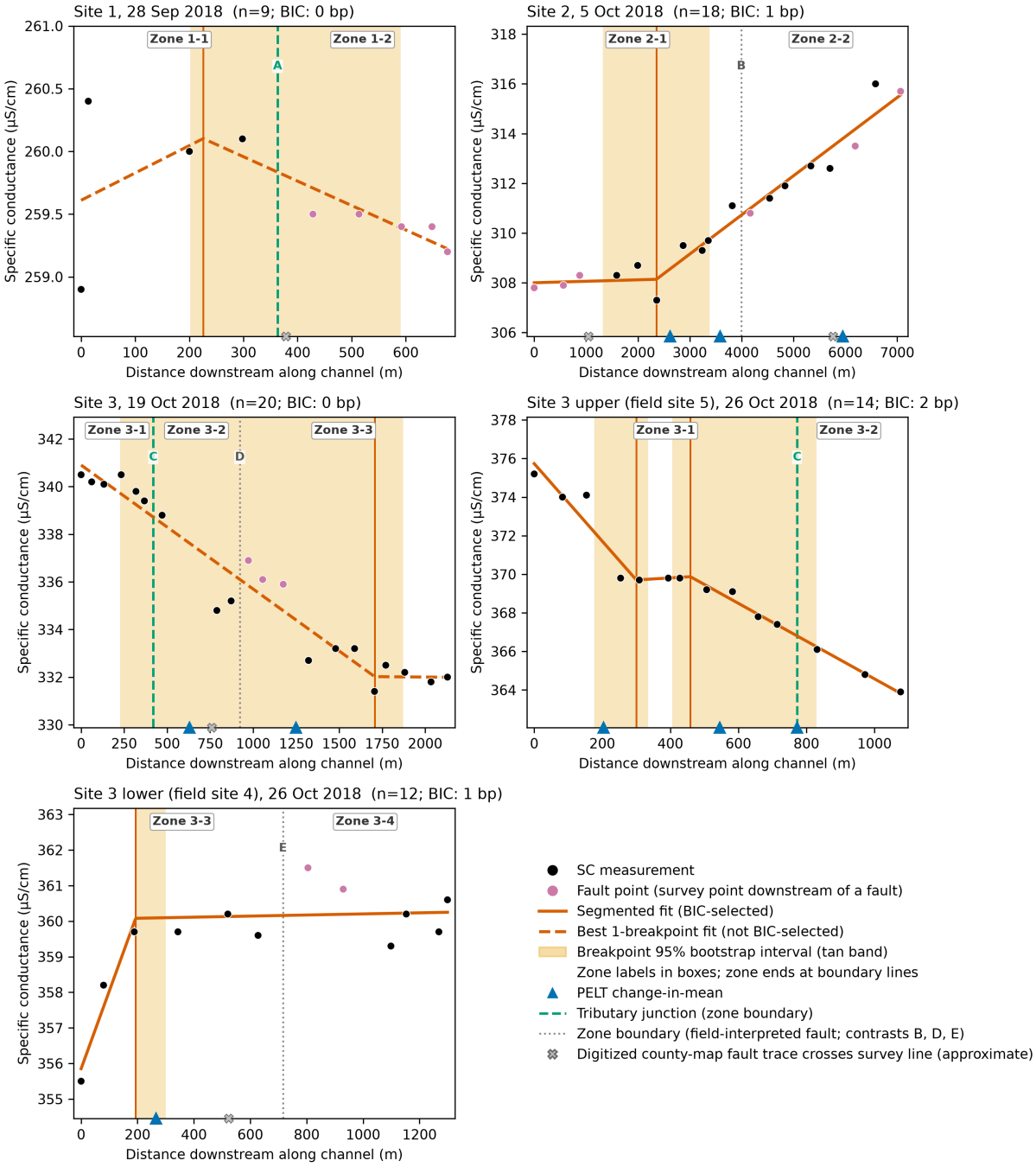


Figure 6: Specific conductance along each single-day transect, with segmented fits (orange; dashed where no breakpoint is selected) and 95% breakpoint intervals (tan). Pink points are fault points; blue triangles are change-in-mean shifts; gray crosses are digitized fault-trace crossings; green and gray lines are tributary and fault-contrast zone boundaries.

Table 2: Autocorrelation-adjusted tests and road distances for Table 1. $\hat{\rho}_1$ is the lag-1 autocorrelation and $n_{\text{eff}} = n(1-\rho)/(1+\rho)$ the effective sample size; adjusted p-values are a sensitivity check. Road distances are zone medians to the nearest primary or secondary road and were not tested.

Contr.	Date	Zones	$\hat{\rho}_1$	$n_{\text{eff},1}$	$n_{\text{eff},2}$	p (Welch)	p (n_{eff})	Median road dist. (m)	
								up	down
A	28 Sep	1-1→1-2	-0.27	4.0	5.0	0.264	0.264	927	751
B	5 Oct	2-1→2-2	0.37	4.6	3.7	<0.001	0.017	335	726
C	19 Oct	3-1→3-2	-0.35	6.0	3.0	0.093	0.093	304	425
C	26 Oct	3-1→3-2	0.54	3.2	2.0	<0.001	0.041	245	414
D	19 Oct	3-2→3-3	0.35	2.0	5.3	0.140	0.279	425	409
E	26 Oct	3-3→3-4	0.30	3.2	3.2	0.090	0.243	312	368

4 Discussion

4.1 Contrasts

Our survey offers little support for the hypothesis that fault zones route road-salt-contaminated groundwater to Wappinger Creek. Of the three fault contrasts, one shows a small, significant increase in specific conductance (Contrast B, $+4.3$ μS/cm), one shows a non-significant decrease (Contrast D, -2.8 μS/cm) and one shows a non-significant increase within instrument accuracy (Contrast E, $+1.6$ μS/cm). No conductance breakpoint on any transect coincides with a fault contrast boundary. Of the three predictions in the Introduction, the first, an abrupt step at a fault, is not met at any crossing; the second could not be tested, because Sites 1 and 2 were surveyed at high flow; and the third was examined only with a single chloride transect and no bromide.

Contrast B is an observation worth testing, not evidence of fault transport. It is a gradual rise that begins roughly 1.6 km upstream of the zone boundary, which marks the fault position we interpreted in the field at an abrupt channel bend, along a reach where the county-scale fault trace runs parallel to the creek and cannot show where the fault meets the channel. A rise of this kind is what diffuse groundwater input, or a fault-parallel flowpath delivering water along the reach, would both produce, and the survey cannot tell them apart. Contrast D, at a fault with no tributary, shows no increase. Contrast E is within the instrument's stated accuracy and its only breakpoint lies near the start of a short transect, 330 m upstream of where the channel crosses the trace. The 2020 chloride transect adds a further observation worth testing: its peak lies near the Contrast D fault points and about 300 m from the nearest trace, but it rests on one sample, comes from a different year, and chloride near Contrast E is low (about 14–15 mg/L). We do not treat the chloride peak as support for the conductance result at any contrast.

The tributary contrast is an internal check. Contrast C decreases conductance on both days, as two-end-member mixing predicts when lower-conductance water joins the main stem [23], so the survey can detect a known input of the size we are discussing.

The size of the differences also matters. The stated accuracy of the conductivity measurement is a bound on absolute error, and a calibration offset common to all readings on one day cancels in a within-day difference, but random reading error does not, and the manufacturer gives no repeatability figure. Contrast B exceeds that bound by a factor of about 2.5 and exceeds the within-zone scatter, which is why we report it as a statistically significant but small difference; Contrast E does not exceed it. Site 1, where a coincident tributary and very high flow after rain confound the only contrast, contributes little either way. Taken together, the survey is best read as a screening result: it shows what a low-cost survey can detect, namely a small gradual rise at one site and the dilution at a tributary, and it also shows that such a survey does not locate a fault-related input to within the spacing of a few hundred meters that a fault trace of uncertain position would require.

4.2 Alternative explanations

Several explanations for the Site 2 increase, and for the conductance differences generally, are at least as plausible as fault-routed groundwater with the data in hand.

Road proximity. Per-zone median distances from survey points to the nearest major road range from 245 to 927 m (Table 2). At Site 2 the downstream zone is farther from a major road than the upstream zone (median 726 versus 335 m), so proximity to a major road does not by itself explain Contrast B, although one upstream point lies only 39 m from a road and the distances do not capture drainage or road density. The Site 3 zones lie 245–425 m from the nearest major road, mainly US 44, with no monotone relation to the conductance pattern. These are descriptive medians, not

a test, and they say nothing about salt stored in roadside soils and shallow groundwater, which may be flushed to the channel late in the season and which our survey cannot distinguish from deeper, fault-routed water. Our surveys were made in late September and October, so a late-season release of such stored salt is a possibility we cannot exclude; it would, like diffuse groundwater, favor a gradual rise over a step.

Developed land. Stream conductance also rises near developed land from sources unrelated to faults or highways, such as residential runoff and lawn and agricultural fertilizers. Site 2 runs beside US 44 and ends near the settled area around Titusville (Figure 3); we did not quantify land cover. Sampling within conserved land does not let us discount such inputs, because the sources lie in the contributing area and not only along the survey line.

Wastewater. Kelly et al. [12] estimated sodium chloride sources for the East Branch of Wappinger Creek and found that road salt contributed 83% and parking-area salt 8% (91% from deicing), sewage including septic systems 4%, and water softeners 3%. The Millbrook sewage treatment plant that they describe is upstream of all three of our sites, about 2.4 km along the channel above Site 3 and 15.3 and 25.3 km above Sites 1 and 2 (EPA ECHO facility locations). As a continuous upstream source it would raise baseline conductance but would not by itself create a step at a zone boundary. More relevant to Contrast B, two small private plants, Stratford Farms and Ennis Mobile Home Park, have listed locations 240–370 m from Zone 2-1 (Figure 3), at about 1.6 and 0.9 km along the survey, upstream of the 2.36 km breakpoint and, for the former, within its 1.3–3.4 km bootstrap interval. These are facility locations rather than outfalls, and flows are not listed, so we cannot test whether they contribute, but they are a plausible, untested alternative source for the Site 2 increase. The Titusville plant lies just downstream of the last Site 2 survey point, so it cannot affect Contrast B, and the Valley Dale plant discharges to a tributary about 2 km away, off the frame of Figure 3.

Diffuse groundwater. Groundwater entering diffusely along a reach would raise conductance gradually downstream rather than in a step, and longitudinal surveys elsewhere show that local groundwater inputs and land use drive spatial variation in stream chloride [26]; the gradual ramp at Site 2 is consistent with such inputs. Long-term records show that stream chloride in the East Branch has risen from roughly 15 mg/L in the mid-1980s to over 40 mg/L by the mid-2000s [12], consistent with a regional anthropogenic source and a large store of salt in the subsurface [14], but a single monitoring location cannot show where along the channel that salt enters.

4.3 Comparison with other studies and implications

The studies of fault-zone hydrogeology in the Introduction, including those in New England metamorphic bedrock [15, 16, 18, 19], make fault-routed delivery plausible, but none of them involves road salt, and none tests it.

Other longitudinal surveys locate salt-laden groundwater inputs more directly than ours. Electromagnetic mapping of a New Hampshire streambed found discrete reaches of high-conductivity discharge [24], and streambed conductivity and temperature mapping in urban streams found porewater chloride ranging from under 100 to over 5000 mg/L within about 10 m [25]. Longitudinal chloride and radon-222 in mixed-land-use streams showed that local groundwater inputs and land use drive spatial variation [26], and long-term sampling of chloride in streams and springs has been used to trace groundwater-sourced road salt, with the highest chloride in a karst watershed in Pennsylvania occurring in summer baseflow [33]. Compared with these approaches, a thalweg survey at roughly 100–400 m spacing integrates over the whole channel flow and is less sensitive to focused inputs that vary over 10 m, so it could miss a real fault signal as well as report a spurious one.

The evidence here does not justify changing deicing practice on the basis of fault locations. Mapped faults are at most a candidate screening layer, to be tested with the design in Section 4.4 before any use in salt management. Measures that reduce the total salt load, such as lower application rates, calibrated equipment, brine-based anti-icing and staff training, as recommended by the Adirondack Road Salt Reduction Task Force [34], remain the better-supported response everywhere.

4.4 Limitations and a test of the hypothesis

Several limitations constrain how far these results can be taken, and we state them plainly because they shape what the survey can and cannot say. We have no discharge measurements, so we cannot estimate the volume of any groundwater input, convert conductance to load, or separate dilution from addition. We have no source tracers, so we cannot attribute salt to roads, wastewater or other sources.

Each reading is a single thalweg value, with no repeats across the channel or at depth, so lateral and vertical variation, which could exceed the small contrasts, is unmeasured. This matters because Contrasts B and E are close to the instrument's stated accuracy (Section 4.1), and we cannot rule out that reading error accounts for part of Contrast B. At Site 3 we surveyed on two days; the reach repeated on both days gave an offset that varied by about 6 μS/cm

(Section 3.1), too much to tie the days together, which limited us to within-day comparisons of small zones and left Contrast D untestable on 26 October.

The chloride data are weaker still. They come from a single transect in a different year, measured with an ion-selective electrode whose stated accuracy ($\pm$15% of reading or $\pm$5 mg/L) is a substantial fraction of the concentrations we measured; only the larger differences, such as the 50 and 40 mg/L peaks against a background of about 14–25 mg/L, exceed it. We therefore treat the chloride results as descriptive.

The fault traces come from a county-scale map whose locations Budnik et al. describe as largely conjectural and for which no positional accuracy is stated, so we draw them as lines and cannot say how far a real fault lies from any mapped position. This is admittedly a weakness for a study whose hypothesis is spatial: if a mapped trace is off by a few hundred meters, a real step could fall outside the zone boundaries we tested. Field mapping of the fault zone at each crossing would remove this uncertainty. Statistically, our zones contain only three to eleven points. Finally, three fault contrasts in one lithology cannot support a general statement about faults; testing whether any pattern holds would need many crossings in several rock types.

The survey nonetheless suggests how the fault-conduit hypothesis could be tested. Our Site 3 data show why surveys should be completed within a single day, or tied across days by repeated points at a steady offset: pooling the two survey days produces an apparent 18 μS/cm step at the second fault that is entirely the offset between days. Paired discharge measurements would turn conductance into load and separate dilution from addition; chloride-to-bromide ratios would fingerprint deicing salt against wastewater and other sources [28]; and environmental age tracers would indicate whether water entering near a fault is older groundwater [35]. Repeated cross-channel and depth readings would show whether small contrasts exceed lateral variation, fault zones should be located in the field rather than from county maps, and surveys should cover several lithologies and many crossings, with change-point analysis applied to single-day transects so that gradual ramps and abrupt steps can be distinguished.

5 Conclusions

We asked whether high-angle fault zones route road-salt-contaminated groundwater to Wappinger Creek, and our survey does not answer the question clearly. Comparing specific conductance within single survey days, we found a small but significant increase of 4.3 μS/cm at one of three fault contrasts (Site 2), about 2.5 times the instrument's stated accuracy. However, change-point analysis suggests that this increase is part of a gradual rise beginning roughly 1.6 km upstream of the channel bend where we placed the fault, rather than a step at it, and two private wastewater plants beside that reach offer an alternative explanation we could not test. At the other two faults, conductance either did not increase or rose by less than the instrument's accuracy, and no conductance breakpoint on any transect coincided with a fault contrast boundary. The tributary contrast behaved as mixing predicts, which gives us some confidence that the survey can detect a known input. The single chloride transect from 2020 peaked near a different fault, but that peak rests on one sample.

We believe the most transferable result is methodological. When we pooled the two Site 3 survey days, the second fault appeared as the largest and most significant step in the survey (18.0 μS/cm), but within a single day the contrast was only $+1.6$ μS/cm; the apparent step was an artifact of the offset between days. Longitudinal surveys aimed at locating point inputs therefore need single-day sampling, or repeated points that tie survey days together at a steady offset, effective sample sizes that account for spatial autocorrelation, and analyses that can distinguish gradual ramps from abrupt steps.

Nevertheless, we do not think the hypothesis should be set aside. Studies of fault zones in fractured and metamorphic rock make fault-routed delivery plausible, and our survey was not designed to rule it out. We therefore regard the fault-conduit hypothesis as plausible but unresolved by this survey. A conclusive test would follow the design in Section 4.4, with single-day surveys, discharge measurements and tracers. Until such a test is done, we suggest that mapped faults be treated as a candidate screening layer to evaluate, not as a basis for changing deicing practice.

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Conflict of interest

The authors declare that they have no conflict of interest.

Data Availability

Both the data, and the code, to reproduce figures and statistics from this paper are made available at the following GitHub Repository: `https://github.com/taddyb/wappingers_road_salts`. All individual specific-conductance measurements are also listed in Appendix A. Road and stream layers are from the US Census Bureau TIGER/Line 2024 files and the USGS National Hydrography Dataset, and wastewater facility locations are from EPA ECHO (retrieved 2026-11-08).

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A Survey measurements

Table A1 lists every specific-conductance measurement from the 2018 survey: the field site and point number, the survey date, the along-channel distance from the upstream end of each single-day transect, the position, specific conductance (SC, μS/cm), water temperature (T, °C), the zone, and whether the point is a fault point, located downstream of a fault (Fault: yes).

Table A1: All specific-conductance (SC) measurements, 28 September–26 October 2018 survey. Distance is along-channel from the upstream end of each survey (field site; haversine sum of GPS fixes).

Site	Field	Pt	Date	Dist (m)	Lat	Lon	SC	T	Zone	Fault
1	1	1	2018-09-28	0	41.80363	-73.78189	258.9	15.3	1-1	no
1	1	2	2018-09-28	13	41.80370	-73.78202	260.4	15.2	1-1	no
1	1	3	2018-09-28	200	41.80275	-73.78388	260.0	15.2	1-1	no
1	1	4	2018-09-28	298	41.80314	-73.78494	260.1	15.2	1-1	no
1	1	5	2018-09-28	428	41.80420	-73.78561	259.5	15.2	1-2	yes
1	1	6	2018-09-28	514	41.80359	-73.78623	259.5	15.2	1-2	yes
1	1	7	2018-09-28	592	41.80295	-73.78663	259.4	15.2	1-2	yes
1	1	8	2018-09-28	649	41.80251	-73.78697	259.4	15.2	1-2	yes
1	1	9	2018-09-28	677	41.80237	-73.78726	259.2	15.2	1-2	yes
2	2	1	2018-10-05	0	41.74113	-73.83050	307.8	15.4	2-1	yes
2	2	2	2018-10-05	563	41.73644	-73.83305	307.9	15.4	2-1	yes
2	2	3	2018-10-05	878	41.73422	-73.83541	308.3	15.4	2-1	yes
2	2	4	2018-10-05	1591	41.72798	-73.83739	308.3	15.5	2-1	no
2	2	5	2018-10-05	1995	41.72470	-73.83949	308.7	15.6	2-1	no
2	2	6	2018-10-05	2362	41.72140	-73.83969	307.3	15.5	2-1	no
2	2	7	2018-10-05	2872	41.71792	-73.84369	309.5	15.6	2-1	no
2	2	8	2018-10-05	3240	41.71499	-73.84574	309.3	15.6	2-1	no
2	2	9	2018-10-05	3357	41.71397	-73.84609	309.7	15.6	2-1	no
2	2	10	2018-10-05	3820	41.71455	-73.85161	311.1	15.7	2-1	no
2	2	11	2018-10-05	4166	41.71193	-73.85387	310.8	15.7	2-2	yes
2	2	12	2018-10-05	4540	41.70899	-73.85606	311.4	15.7	2-2	no
2	2	13	2018-10-05	4836	41.70650	-73.85732	311.9	15.8	2-2	no
2	2	14	2018-10-05	5335	41.70284	-73.86080	312.7	15.8	2-2	no
2	2	15	2018-10-05	5704	41.69994	-73.86296	312.6	15.8	2-2	no
2	2	16	2018-10-05	6191	41.69676	-73.86699	313.5	15.7	2-2	yes
2	2	17	2018-10-05	6582	41.69324	-73.86698	316.0	15.8	2-2	no
2	2	18	2018-10-05	7066	41.68951	-73.86997	315.7	15.8	2-2	yes
3	3	1	2018-10-19	0	41.79652	-73.71534	340.5	9.4	3-1	no
3	3	2	2018-10-19	61	41.79607	-73.71577	340.2	9.4	3-1	no
3	3	3	2018-10-19	133	41.79582	-73.71656	340.1	9.5	3-1	no
3	3	4	2018-10-19	233	41.79613	-73.71770	340.5	9.5	3-1	no
3	3	5	2018-10-19	319	41.79673	-73.71835	339.8	9.6	3-1	no
3	3	6	2018-10-19	368	41.79674	-73.71894	339.4	9.5	3-1	no
3	3	7	2018-10-19	471	41.79639	-73.72009	338.8	9.6	3-2	no
3	3	8	2018-10-19	789	41.79467	-73.72316	334.8	9.7	3-2	no
3	3	9	2018-10-19	872	41.79394	-73.72337	335.2	9.7	3-2	no
3	3	10	2018-10-19	973	41.79374	-73.72455	336.9	9.7	3-3	yes
3	3	11	2018-10-19	1056	41.79331	-73.72537	336.1	9.7	3-3	yes
3	3	12	2018-10-19	1175	41.79251	-73.72633	335.9	9.8	3-3	yes
3	3	13	2018-10-19	1322	41.79155	-73.72755	332.7	10.0	3-3	no
3	3	14	2018-10-19	1479	41.79168	-73.72944	333.2	10.0	3-3	no
3	3	15	2018-10-19	1590	41.79136	-73.73070	333.2	10.0	3-3	no
3	3	16	2018-10-19	1706	41.79091	-73.73196	331.4	10.0	3-3	no

Site	Field	Pt	Date	Dist (m)	Lat	Lon	SC	T	Zone	Fault
3	3	17	2018-10-19	1771	41.79048	-73.73142	332.5	10.1	3-3	no
3	3	18	2018-10-19	1881	41.78949	-73.73137	332.2	10.1	3-3	no
3	3	19	2018-10-19	2034	41.78819	-73.73197	331.8	10.2	3-3	no
3	3	20	2018-10-19	2130	41.78765	-73.73287	332.0	10.2	3-3	no
3	5	14	2018-10-26	0	41.79600	-73.71273	375.2	8.7	3-1	no
3	5	13	2018-10-26	83	41.79581	-73.71370	374.0	8.7	3-1	no
3	5	12	2018-10-26	154	41.79640	-73.71401	374.1	8.7	3-1	no
3	5	11	2018-10-26	254	41.79660	-73.71519	369.8	8.8	3-1	no
3	5	10	2018-10-26	309	41.79614	-73.71543	369.7	8.8	3-1	no
3	5	9	2018-10-26	394	41.79573	-73.71630	369.8	8.7	3-1	no
3	5	8	2018-10-26	428	41.79556	-73.71664	369.8	8.7	3-1	no
3	5	7	2018-10-26	507	41.79607	-73.71730	369.2	8.8	3-1	no
3	5	6	2018-10-26	583	41.79652	-73.71799	369.1	8.8	3-1	no
3	5	5	2018-10-26	658	41.79688	-73.71876	367.8	8.8	3-1	no
3	5	4	2018-10-26	714	41.79656	-73.71928	367.4	8.8	3-1	no
3	5	3	2018-10-26	831	41.79620	-73.72061	366.1	8.7	3-2	no
3	5	2	2018-10-26	972	41.79515	-73.72156	364.8	8.8	3-2	no
3	5	1	2018-10-26	1077	41.79478	-73.72272	363.9	8.9	3-2	no
3	4	1	2018-10-26	0	41.78772	-73.73268	355.5	8.3	3-3	no
3	4	2	2018-10-26	80	41.78704	-73.73298	358.2	8.2	3-3	no
3	4	3	2018-10-26	188	41.78674	-73.73423	359.7	8.2	3-3	no
3	4	4	2018-10-26	343	41.78550	-73.73508	359.7	8.1	3-3	no
3	4	5	2018-10-26	520	41.78416	-73.73623	360.2	8.1	3-3	no
3	4	6	2018-10-26	628	41.78364	-73.73732	359.6	8.2	3-3	no
3	4	7	2018-10-26	804	41.78239	-73.73864	361.5	8.1	3-4	yes
3	4	8	2018-10-26	930	41.78302	-73.73989	360.9	8.1	3-4	yes
3	4	9	2018-10-26	1099	41.78305	-73.74193	359.3	8.3	3-4	no
3	4	10	2018-10-26	1153	41.78323	-73.74254	360.2	8.3	3-4	no
3	4	11	2018-10-26	1269	41.78308	-73.74392	359.7	8.4	3-4	no
3	4	12	2018-10-26	1299	41.78325	-73.74421	360.6	8.3	3-4	no